

# Housetraining your puppy



*Accidents are information, not misbehaviour. Your puppy has a small bladder and hasn't yet learned where the toilet is. Your job is to prevent mistakes and make the right place the best place in the world.*

## 1. WRITE IT DOWN

- Put a **written schedule** on the fridge: meals, toilet breaks, rest. Everyone in the house follows it.
- Keep an **elimination journal** for two weeks: time, place, what happened. Patterns show quickly.

## 2. WHEN TO GO OUT

- On waking, including after naps
- After meals and drinks
- After play
- Before bed, and in the night while very young
- Take water up about two hours before bedtime

Under 3 months bladder control is still developing; it improves a lot at 4–6 months. Small dogs have smaller bladders and feel the cold.

## 3. AT THE TOILET SPOT

1. Go to the **same spot**, on lead.
2. **Stay with your puppy.** You can only reward what you see.
3. Say “**go potty**” *just as* it begins to go.
4. **Reward straight away** with praise and a treat.
5. Then give a **few minutes of free play outside**. Only after that, go in.

**Why the play matters:** going straight in teaches your puppy that going means the fun ends, so it holds on. Keep rewarding well past the first successes. A little of your puppy's own urine or poop left at the spot helps it choose that surface.

## 4. THE CRATE

- Big enough to stand, sit, turn and lie down, but not so big it can use one end as a toilet. Use a **divider** that moves as it grows.
- Dogs avoid soiling where they sleep. That is why it works.
- A **safe den, never a punishment**. Feed meals in it; give food-filled toys.
- Keep it in a central room so your puppy is part of the family.
- **Don't open the door while it whines.** Wait for a moment of quiet.
- When you can't watch, use the crate or **baby gates** to keep it in a small area you can see.

## 5. WHEN THERE'S AN ACCIDENT

- **No punishment.** No shouting, no rubbing a nose in it. It teaches your puppy to hide.
- Clean with an **enzymatic cleaner**. Ordinary cleaners leave a scent that invites a repeat.
- Carry a kit when out: enzymatic spray, bags, wipes.

## 6. WE ADVISE AGAINST

- **Pee pads and litter boxes.** They teach that indoors is acceptable, and a dog trained only on one may struggle to go elsewhere. Exceptions: small dogs with elderly or disabled owners, and flats (pads in a playpen for the first few months, then grass).
- **Dog doors** in the early weeks. You can't supervise or reward.
- **Tethering** to you or to furniture. Use a crate, or teach “**place**”: your puppy goes to a spot and stays until released.

## 7. A BELL ON THE DOOR

Only if you answer it **every single time**. Some dogs learn to ring it just to get outside to play.

## 8. COMMON PROBLEMS

- **Wees when greeting:** involuntary, usually outgrown. Stay calm, keep greetings quiet, and pet on the chest, not over the head.
- **Eats its own poop:** clean up straight away. Change diet only on your vet's advice.
- **Upset stomach:** stress, diet changes and treats. Avoid hot dogs (too salty); boiled unseasoned chicken, sparingly.
- **Marking:** behavioural (a new pet) or medical. Have the vet check.
- **Rescue or puppy-farm puppies:** often used to living in dirt. It takes longer. Be patient.

## 9. CALL YOUR VET IF

A dog that was reliably house-trained suddenly has accidents. It can mean a urinary infection, incontinence, a weak bladder or diabetes.